Forgive Me, Leonard Peacock

By Matthew Quick

LEONARD: **(Pg 99)** In elementary school the teachers always remembered your birthday. There were cupcakes and everyone sang in a way that made you feel really special and a part of something. There's a reason the elementary teachers did that. It was important. **(Pg 110)** You know what? F*** Linda for forgetting my birthday. **(Pg 9)** Linda is my mother. I call her Linda because it annoys her. She says it "de-moms" her. But she de-mommed herself when she rented an apartment in Manhattan and left me all alone to fend for myself most weeks. She checked out of my life – maybe because it was too intense for her to handle. I don't know. **(Pg 110)** *(Emotions begin to build – a mix of anger and tears)* How do you forget giving birth to someone eighteen years ago today? [It's] IRRESPONSIBLE and selfish and culpable and inhumane and . . . **(Pg 170)** Let's get this birthday party started!

INTRODUCTION

Today is Leonard Peacock's 18th birthday. He is a loner, an outcast, a misfit and maybe one day he'll believe that being different is okay, important even. But not today. Today he plans to commit suicide. Unless one caring teacher can convince him that the daily battle of not letting the world destroy you is worth the work.

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LEONARD: **(Pg 109-111)** I want someone to figure it out to piece together all the hints I've been dropping all day long, for years and years even, but no one ever figures it out, and I'm beginning to see why people go mad and do awful things – like the Nazis and Hitler and Timothy McVeigh and Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold did. They all have a lot in common. I bet they felt lonely, helpless, FORGOTTEN, ignored, alienated, irrelevant, cynical and sad.

SILVERMAN: Leonard?

LEONARD: Herr Silverman looks into my eyes until I look back into his. **(Pg 114)** There have been days when Herr Silverman was the only person to look me in the eye. The only person all day long. It's a simple thing, but simple things matter. **(Pg 110-111)** I plead with him

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using mental telepathy, thinking, "Please just move on. It's my birthday. I only have a few more hours on this planet. Please. Be kind. Let me off the hook." The uber-morons roll their eyes and exchange glances. [And] he moves on. **(Pg 113)** I mostly tune out and wait for class to end so I can be closer to the Leonard Peacock finish line. **(Pg 114-115)** [But] when the bell rings, I stay seated.

SILVERMAN: *(closing the classroom door)* So, you wanted to speak with me?

LEONARD: I reach into my backpack and pull out a small box. "This is for you." It's the Bronze Star medal my grandfather was awarded for killing some high-ranking Nazi back in World War Two.

SILVERMAN: **(Pg 116)** Why are you giving this to me?

LEONARD: I don't know. But I want you to have it, okay? It's important to me. Maybe you can keep it in your desk drawer and whenever you get to feeling like maybe teaching isn't worth it anymore you can think of that crazy kid Leonard Peacock who loved your class and gave you [this] as a reward for being an excellent teacher. Maybe it will help you keep going. I don't know. *(Awkward silence)*

SILVERMAN: **(Pg 117)** I'm just going to say this, Leonard, and I hope you won't take offense. Sudden changes in appearance. You did cut your hair, right?

LEONARD: **(Pg 11)** I have [had] this signature really long dirty-blond hair that [hung] over my eyes and past my shoulders.

SILVERMAN: **(Pg 117-118)** Giving away treasured possessions. These are clear signs. Suicidal people often do these things. I'm worried you might be at risk. Are you trying to tell me something here today?

LEONARD: *(looking down)* Not really. I just wanted you to know how much your class means to me. *(to audience)* I reach down deep within myself and put on the Hollywood face. *(smiles and laughs, then speaks to Silverman)* I probably would want to kill myself if I didn't get to spend time in this room every day. Your class is probably the only thing keeping me alive. *(long silence)* Can I ask you a personal question? **(Pg 119)** Why don't you ever roll up your sleeves or wear a short-sleeve shirt?

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SILVERMAN: You noticed that, huh? *(pause)* **(Pg 120-121)** Are you sure you're feeling okay?

LEONARD: Yeah, I'm sure. I'm off to see my guidance counselor right now, actually. So even if I were messed up, super-counselor Mrs. Shanahan'll fix me straight with a root beer lollipop before I leave the building, so no worries, right?

SILVERMAN: *(writing down a number on a piece of paper)* If I give you my cell phone number will you promise to call me if you feel like you're going to kill yourself? Call me first so I can tell you the reason I never roll up my sleeves. I bet knowing the answer to that question will make you feel better, but let's save it for when you're feeling really bad.

LEONARD: He's going above and beyond for me. And h e's also breaking the rules – giving me his cell phone number. No other teacher in the building would do this. And it makes me so sad to think he'll be really upset when he hears about my suicide.

SILVERMAN: So will you promise me that you'll call if it gets worse – before you do anything rash? I'll tell you the answer if you call. It's a big secret. But I'll tell you, Leonard, because I think you need to know. You're different. And I'm different too. Different is good. But different is hard. Believe me, I know.

LEONARD: **(Pg 122)** If only the world were full of Herr Silvermans. But it isn't. I don't go to Guidance. No root beer lollipop today. I have a mission to complete. **(Pg 129)** I exit my town's train station, and this girl I had never seen before stuck a piece of paper in my face.

GIRL: The way, the truth, and the light! Read all about it! Jesus Christ died for your sins! Jesus loves you.

LEONARD: **(Pg 174)** [NOPE!] Hellfire is not in the plans. Heaven is not in the plans. Uber-nothing. That's what I want. Nothing. **(Pg 197)** I end up by the river under this little bridge. **(Pg 200-206)** I've got the gun to my temple now and I'm rubbing the side of my head into the metal O. I push the P-38's mouth harder and deeper into the soft spot of my skull. It's like the P-38 is an old skeleton key I'm trying to fit into an old padlock and when I make that connection I'll hear a click and a door will open and I'll walk through and be saved. *(whispering)* "Make the lock click, Leonard. You just have to squeeze your index finger and everything will be okay. The thoughts will stop. No more problems. You can finally just

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rest. I close my eyes. Time comes to a standstill. *(screams)* **(Pg 208)** F****!! I bang my fist against the concrete wall, but no matter what I do, no matter how hard I try, I can't seem to get my trigger finger to work. I just can't seem to blow my brains out. *(searches frantically through his pockets for the paper that Herr Silverman gave to him, he finds it and dials the number on his cell phone – his breathing is ragged and filled with emotions, but as the phone begins to ring, his breathing quiets)*

SILVERMAN: **(Pg 209)** Hello? . . . *(silence)* Hello? *(silence) (then in a softer voice)* Is this Leonard? *(Silence)* Just tell me where you are, Leonard. I'll come to you. We can talk. I'll tell you my secret. I'll roll up my sleeves for you.

LEONARD: **(Pg 211)** *(in a broken voice)* It's my birthday today. No one remembered. *(to audience)* It sounds so stupid and pathetic and little-kid whiny that I push the P-38's barrel into my temple again. *(to himself)* End this. Just pull the trigger. Make it easier for everyone.

SILVERMAN: Happy birthday, Leonard.

LEONARD: *(to audience)* Just two words. Happy birthday. It makes me feel like I'm not already gone. Like I'm still here. I lower the P-38 and tell him where I am.

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SILVERMAN: **(Pg 216)** Just give me the gun and everything will be okay.

LEONARD: No it won't. That's such a f***** lie! **(Pg 41)** [I've watched adults on the train going to their jobs in the city. They . . .] just sit there or stand. No one talks. [They] grimly read the paper, angrily poke smartphone screens and barely even blink. I never want to be an adult. **(Pg 216)** You don't lie, Herr Silverman. You're better than the rest. You're the only adult I really trust and look up to. So tell me something else, okay? Try again. *(sarcastically)*

SILVERMAN: **(Pg 218-219)** *(steps closer to Leonard, takes off his coat and starts to roll up his right sleeve – he uses his cell phone to light his wrist)* Take a look.

LEONARD: *(to audience)* I don't see scars or needle marks or anything like that. It's a tattoo of a pink triangle – what the Nazis used to label homosexuals in the concentration camps. I know because Herr Silverman taught us that. *(To Silverman)* Who did that to you?

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SILVERMAN: I did it to myself.

LEONARD: Why?

SILVERMAN: I tried to be who I thought the world wanted me to be all through high school. Always trying to please everyone else – keeping my true self invisible. It took me 19 years to figure out who I was and another twelve or so months to admit it. I didn't ever want to forget again. I tattooed my wrist with a symbol. So the answer would always be there. **(Pg 220-221)** *(begins to roll up his other sleeve)*

LEONARD: The words are printed in navy blue – simple block letters stacked in two rows. The message to himself and no one else. "First they ignore you, then they laugh at you, then they fight you, then you win."

SILVERMAN: It's often attributed to Gandhi. It [makes] me feel strong. [Gives] me hope. [Keeps] me going.

LEONARD: I'm not like you. *(raises the P-38 to his temple again)* This is me. Right here. Right now.

SILVERMAN: No, it's not you at all. I've looked into your eyes when I lecture. I can tell you get it – you're different. And I know how hard being different can be. But I also know how powerful a weapon being different can be. How the world needs such weapons. Gandhi was different. All great people are. And unique people such as you and me need to seek out other unique people who understand – so we don't get too lonely and end up where you did tonight.

LEONARD: **(Pg 223)** [And then] I tell him everything. Every. Horrible. Stomach-wrenching. Detail. And I'm crying again because I just can't help it. **(Pg 225)** *(to Silverman)* . . . I feel like I'm broken – like I don't fit together anymore. Like I've overstayed my welcome here on Earth and everyone's trying to give me hints about that constantly. I think that's why my mom left for New York and why no one wants to talk to me ever. I'm worthless. *(looks down at the P-38 and sighs)* I can't even kill myself properly.

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SILVERMAN: That's a good thing . . . That's a beautiful thing. **(Pg 228)** Throw the gun in the river, Leonard. rust in the future. Go ahead. Do it. It's okay. Things are going to get better. You can do the work. *(long pause as Leonard considers his options)*

LEONARD: I take three quick steps toward the water and throw the P-38 like a boomerang.

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AWARD HISTORY

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